

Animated Storyboard Assignment

"The Turning Point" — A Fitness App User Journey

Discipline: Narrative Design / Motion Graphics / UX Storytelling **Level:** Industry / Professional Portfolio Piece **Format:** 8-12 panel animated storyboard (static frames + motion/transition notes) **Duration of final animatic:** 60-90 seconds

1. Assignment Overview

You are the narrative designer on a fitness app's brand team. Your task is to storyboard a short animated sequence (used for onboarding, an ad, or an in-app "your journey" moment) that follows a single user, **Maya**, through a believable emotional arc — from struggle to a hard-won, sustainable sense of progress.

This is not a montage of workouts. It is a character-driven story. The brief exists to test whether you can translate psychological and narrative theory into visual sequence, pacing, and dialogue/UI-copy choices.

Your storyboard must demonstrably encode **five narrative competencies**, detailed below. Each competency maps to specific panels, choices, and annotations you are required to produce.

2. The Five Competencies (and what each looks like on the page)

A. Recognize Emotional Journeys in Stories

Your storyboard must chart a visible **emotional arc**, not just a physical one.

Requirement: Include an "Emotional Beat Line" underneath your storyboard — a simple graph/annotation marking Maya's emotional state at each panel (e.g., Shame → Resistance → Doubt → Small Win → Frustration/Setback → Reconnection → Quiet Confidence). No panel should repeat the previous panel's emotional label; the arc must move.

B. Understand Resilience Narratives

Resilience is not a straight line of improvement — it's a **setback + response** structure.

Requirement: At least one panel must depict a genuine setback (missed workout streak, injury scare, a bad day, comparison to someone else on the app's leaderboard). The following panel must show Maya's *internal choice* to continue — not the app fixing it for her. Annotate this pair as the "Rupture / Repair" beat.

C. Identify Mentor and Support Roles

Every resilience story needs a relational anchor. In this app context, "mentor" can be human, digital, or communal.

Requirement: Introduce one support figure — options include: an AI coach notification with personality, a human trainer via video message, a friend/accountability partner, or a community comment. This character/element must appear at least twice: once *before* the setback (planting trust) and once *after* (offering perspective, not solving the problem for her). Label these panels "Mentor Touchpoint 1" and "Mentor Touchpoint 2."

D. Develop Meaning-Centered Communication

UI copy, notification text, and dialogue should express **why this matters to Maya**, not just what to do next.

Requirement: Write actual copy (not placeholder "insert text") for at least 3 on-screen text moments: a push notification, an in-app message, and Maya's internal thought (shown as caption or voiceover line). None of the three may be purely instructional (e.g., banned: "You completed your workout!"). Each must connect the action to identity, values, or purpose (e.g., "You showed up for yourself today — even on the hard day.").

E. Build Empathy Through Perspective-Taking

The viewer must feel *with* Maya, not just watch her.

Requirement: Choose at least 2 panels to render from Maya's literal or figurative point of view (POV shot looking down at her shoes before a run she doesn't want to take; her phone screen exactly as she sees it; a mirror moment). Annotate camera/framing choices and explain in one sentence per panel why this framing builds empathy rather than observation.

3. Deliverables Checklist

#	Deliverable	Required Elements
1	Character brief (½ page)	Maya's goal, wound/insecurity, and what "winning" actually means to her emotionally
2	Storyboard panels (8-12)	Sketch/frame, camera notes, transition/motion notes, timing (seconds per panel)
3	Emotional Beat Line	Visual graph or labeled strip beneath the storyboard

#	Deliverable	Required Elements
4	Rupture/Repair annotation	Two panels clearly marked
5	Mentor Touchpoint annotations	Two panels clearly marked
6	Written UI/dialogue copy	3 pieces of copy, meaning-centered (per Section D)
7	POV/empathy justification	2 panels with framing rationale
8	Reflection paragraph (150–250 words)	Which competency was hardest to visualize, and why

4. Suggested Story Skeleton (you may deviate)

1. **Ordinary Struggle** — Maya avoids opening the app; establishing shot of daily friction.
2. **Small Trigger** — a notification, a memory, or a mirror moment nudges her in.
3. **First Attempt** — awkward, unpolished effort. Emotional beat: resistance → tentative hope.
4. **Mentor Touchpoint 1** — trust is planted (a coach's tone, a friend's check-in).
5. **Momentum** — short montage compressed into 1–2 panels, not the whole story.
6. **Rupture** — the setback. Keep it specific and small-scale, not catastrophic.
7. **Repair (internal)** — Maya's private choice to continue. No fanfare.
8. **Mentor Touchpoint 2** — perspective offered, not a fix.
9. **Return** — she comes back, changed in attitude more than in appearance.
10. **Meaning Beat** — the emotional payoff line lands here (this is where your best copy goes).
11. **Quiet Confidence** — resist the urge to end on triumph-music energy; end on grounded self-recognition.

5. Evaluation Rubric (100 pts)

Criterion	Weight	What Evaluators Look For
Emotional arc clarity	20	Distinct, non-repeating emotional states; visible movement
Resilience structure	20	Genuine setback; internally-driven repair (not app-driven)

Criterion	Weight	What Evaluators Look For
Mentor/support integration	15	Support figure feels earned, not inserted; appears at both touchpoints
Meaning-centered copy	20	Copy ties action to identity/purpose; avoids generic fitness-app language
Empathy/POV craft	15	Framing choices are intentional and justified, not decorative
Craft & presentation	10	Storyboard is legible, paced, and professionally annotated

Common point-losses: treating the setback as cosmetic; letting the app/mentor solve the emotional problem for Maya; generic motivational copy ("Keep going!", "You got this!") without specificity to her story; POV panels included but not justified.

6. Reference Tone (industry calibration)

Study the emotional pacing (not visuals) of: Nike "Dream Crazier," Peloton's narrative ads (post-2021 rebrand, after the earlier ad's backlash), and Headspace's onboarding illustration sequences. Note how all three under-narrate rather than over-narrate — they trust a small honest beat over a dramatic one.